4. Upon completion of this stage, a series of secret meetings will be held under the leadership of the president of the United States, the prime minister of Israel, and a small team representing each of the parties for a joint presentation of the results of the parties' respective staff work, with the aim of reaching the maximum number of understandings and planning the follow-up processes.
5. Assuming an understanding is reached between the US and Israeli positions, the United States will take it upon itself to persuade or recruit Saudi Arabia, Egypt, Jordan, and the Gulf States (in this order) and, if and when Israel announces that it accepts the 2002 Arab Peace Initiative, to respond positively to the changes that have been added to it in the rounds of the negotiations since then as a basis for final status negotiations between Israel and the Palestinians.
6. If and when the United States succeeds in the aforementioned task (point 5), Israel can then make a public declaration. From that point on, negotiations can proceed in various constellations depending on the matter at hand, in public or in secret, as necessary.

Of course, this roadmap is only a suggested outline, which would be likely to change as progress is made, but it should be emphasized that the stage of secret talks is a vital condition for success.

A New Regional Order in the Middle East: The Only Way Out of the Deadlock

This section was first written after the release of a November 24, 2015, photo of Secretary of State Kerry and Prime Minister Netanyahu, in which the facial expressions of the PM and the secretary testified both to the deep freeze in relations between Israel and the Palestinians and to Israel's relations with the United States. I thought at the time that our geographic location in the Middle East, which had turned into a boiling cauldron, would suck us into it as well if we did not take preventative steps to prevent it and did not think, in an out-of-the-box manner, about what kind of